Svabhava-pratibandha (natural regularity): the key feature of a valid logical inference (*prayoga*) is the invariant association (***vyapti***) between the logical reason (***hetu***) and what is to be established (***sadhya***). According to the Buddhist ***Dharmakirti***, the invariant association (which he also calls 'inseparable linkage' or *avinabhava*) must be guaranteed by some sort of natural regularity. Only thus can we be sure that a universal proposition of the form 'All As are Bs' is true.

His theory of natural regularity attempts to underpin some forms of inseparable connection in the absence of objective universals (***samanya-lakshana***). He holds that we know that the connection between the logical reason and the property to be proved could not be otherwise (*niyama*) when the connection is either that between cause and effect (*tad-utpatti/karya-hetu* – 'fire and smoke') or a case of shared nature (*tadatmya/svabhava-hetu* – 'tree and oak'). This necessary relation is what he calls the natural regularity or *svabhava-pratibandha*. So we may infer from the fact of something's being an oak that it is a tree and from the presence of smoke to the presence of fire. This principle is applied in characteristically Buddhist arguments such as, 'If something is produced, it is perishable by nature'.

Dharmakirti's point is that the invariable association must be more than the product of a finite range of observed instances (*bhuyo-darshana*) as well as the lack of counter-examples (***adarshana-matra***), since that would leave open the possibility of our discovering exceptions in the future.

Dharmakirti thinks that while immediate sensory impressions relate directly to reality that consists of unique instantaneous particulars (***svalakshana***), the mental images and concepts that are formed about them do so indirectly. But ***Dharmakirti*** does not think that all our